

Modal harmony

A mode is another way of ordering pitches to create a particular harmonic structure. They give structure to melodies, especially unaccompanied melodies, but they can also be used within diatonic music.

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Blues and jazz

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Mode in practice

Each mode begins on a different note of the diatonic scale, which lends it an individual character. Because of their origins, they are sometimes known as church modes or Gregorian modes, but they have been used outside religious contexts for centuries in different musical genres. For example, Scottish and Irish folk music often use modes, not only for the melodies but the harmonic accompaniments, too, and this is what lends them their “folky” character.

Mode name	Starting note
Dorian	D
Phrygian	E
Lydian	F
Mixolydian	G
Aeolian	A
Locrian	B
Ionian	C

The structure of a mode

All the modes have their own structure of whole steps and half steps, which gives them their specific character, so that they do not sound like a minor or a major scale. In the diatonic system, a major scale is divided into successive intervals of whole step-whole step-half step-whole step-whole step-whole step-half step—represented in numbers of half steps as 2212221. A natural minor scale is divided as whole step-half step-whole step-whole step-half step-whole step-whole step, or 2122122. The arrangement of the modes in this scheme is shown below.

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Modes in jazz

Miles Davis used modes rather than chord progressions. “So What?”—the first number on *Kind of Blue*—is a superb example of modal jazz, where the bassist works up and down a modal scale and the other musicians improvise in complementary harmony.



Ionian	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step
Dorian	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step
Phrygian	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step
Lydian	Whole step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step
Mixolydian	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step
Aeolian	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step
Locrian	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Half step	Whole step	Whole step	Whole step

◁ Ionian mode

The Ionian mode does sound like a major scale, because it has the same arrangement of whole steps and half steps.



△ Dorian mode

The example on the staff shows the Dorian mode, starting not on its “natural” note of D, but on C.